

3-D-capable PC that comes bundled with a 3-D monitor and glasses is advisable to be sure that you have the right equipment that all work well together.

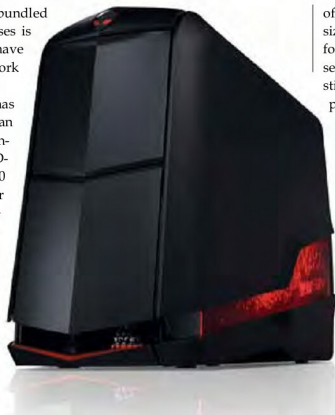
As a 3-D-compliant PC has much higher configuration than a regular PC, it is more expensive than a regular PC. A 3-D-compliant PC costs around 10 per cent more than a regular PC for the same performance and package. But then you are investing in a machine that utilises a high level of technology for a completely new gaming experience.

Dell claims that its Alienware Aurora is ideal for 3-D gaming. It costs Rs 130,000-150,000, depending on the configuration of the machine you opt for. The rest of Alienware range includes gaming laptops, which include M11x starting from Rs 75,000, M15x starting from Rs 99,000 and M17x starting from Rs 125,000. Dell also offers 3-D gaming full-HD-screen monitors.

ASUS too has launched a 3-D laptop—G51J with latest NVIDIA 3-D solution. Equipped with NVIDIA 3-D vision and bundled with specially designed 3-D glasses, the ASUS G51J 3-D sports an NVIDIA GTS360M with 1GB DDR5 video memory and delivers stunning visuals. Powered by an Intel Core i7 processor and 64-bit Windows 7 operating system, the ASUS G51J costs around Rs 109,999 for the total package.

ASUS has also launched a 58.4cm (23-inch) 3-D LCD monitor (VG236), which is priced at Rs 41,000 (excluding taxes). This monitor comes along with NVIDIA 3-D vision kit, so you can connect it to your computer without making much change in it.

Acer's Aspire 5738D series of 3-D notebooks comes in two models, one on the Pentium dual core platform and the other on the Core2Duo platform. It is powered by Intel and has up to 4 GB of DDR3 1066 MHz dual-channel



Dell Alienware Aurora desktop

memory. The Aspire 5738DzG (PDC) costs above Rs 43,000.

Role of graphics card

Video or graphics circuitry, usually fitted to a card but sometimes found on the motherboard itself, is responsible for creating the picture displayed by a monitor. On early text-based PCs, this was a fairly mundane task. However, the advent of graphical operating systems dramatically increased the amount of information to be displayed to levels where it was impractical for it to be handled by the main processor. The solution was to off-load the handling of all screen activity to a more intelligent generation of graphics card.

With multimedia and then 3-D graphics, the role of the graphics card has become ever more important and it has evolved into a highly efficient processing engine that can be viewed as a highly specialised co-processor.

Other things to consider

Many factors affect the purchasing decision of a 3-D gaming device. Some

of the most important ones are screen size, compatibility with various 3-D formats, simplicity and ease of use in setting up the system, quality of 3-D stimulation and type of 3-D glasses provided with the bundle.

Do thorough research before investing in a 3-D gaming device and see which device offers the best possible solution to your gaming needs. "Since 3-D technology is fairly new in the consumer segment, the value differentiators are not very clear in the minds of customers and it will be a while before they can wholly understand the merits and demerits of some of the features," says Huang.

Is the content available?

There is plentiful 3-D gaming content—over 400 games can be played in 3-D. You will see more and more games coming in the 3-D format in the near future. Since most of the games are available on the Web, these can be downloaded from anywhere. *Avatar* is one of the popular games available. Apart from that, there are a lot of companies that are releasing 3-D gaming content in India. If you have the machine, content is just a step away.

Looking forward

Up until quite recently, 3-D was still seen as a fad, but with 3-D TVs launched by every major manufacturer, it's obvious that 3-D is here to stay. 3-D Blu-Ray has been launched and there is 3-D content everywhere, from sports channels broadcasting in 3-D to 3-D YouTube and cinema.

The next wave is definitely 3-D. Within a few months, PS3, which is compatible with 3-D games currently, will also be compatible with 3-D movies. However, for 3-D to become popular, cost has to come down. ●

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